

WHAT TO SAY, BY SITUATION

When the date moves

Nobody is upset that a date moved. Dates move. They are upset they found out when it was too late to move anything else.

I am a senior technical program manager at Microsoft. Most of my job is other people's commitments, which means most of my bad news is not mine and I still have to be the one who says it. The hardest part was never the news. It was the first sentence.

This is five situations and the exact words for each. The shape is the same every time: say the size, say what you already did, say what you need.

1 It might slip and you are not sure yet

This is the one people sit on, because saying something might go wrong feels like admitting it already has. So they wait until they are certain, and by then the options are gone.

Flag the uncertainty. It costs you nothing and it means they hear it from you first.

EXAMPLE

"Heads up, the migration might slip. I will know by Friday. Telling you now so it is not a surprise if it does."

WHY THIS MATTERS: your manager can start looking at what else moves. If you wait until you are sure, the only thing left to tell them is what already happened.

2 It has slipped

Say the new date. Not "we are a bit behind", not "we are pushing hard to catch up". A date they can put in a plan.

Then say what you need to hit it, so the news arrives with a next step attached.

EXAMPLE

"We are going to miss the 14th. I can make the 21st if I get one more engineer for a week. If not, it is the 28th."

WHY THIS MATTERS: a bit behind gives them nothing to act on, so they wait and ask again next week. Two dates and a condition lets them choose.

3 Somebody asked for more scope

The expensive habit here is saying yes without saying the price. Every free yes makes the next request free too, and eventually the date moves and nobody remembers why.

Say yes. Attach the cost. Let them decide.

EXAMPLE

"We can add that. It moves the launch two weeks. Still want it?"

WHY THIS MATTERS: you are not refusing, so there is no argument to have. They can still say yes, and now they are saying yes to the real thing.

4 You are blocked on another team

Still waiting on them is a status about somebody else. It names nobody and asks for nothing, and it makes you sound like a spectator on your own project.

Bring the count and the specific ask.

EXAMPLE

"I have asked their team twice, on the 3rd and the 9th, and I have not got a date back. I need you to raise it with their lead this week."

WHY THIS MATTERS: a count shows you worked it before escalating. A named person and a timeframe gives your manager something they can do today.

5 Something broke

An issue could be a typo or an outage, so the first thing anyone does when they hear it is ask you three questions. Answer them before they are asked.

Size it. Say what you already did. Give a time for the rest.

EXAMPLE

"Payments are down for about five percent of users. We are rolling back now and I will have a root cause by end of day."

WHY THIS MATTERS: your manager has to go tell their own boss something, and that sentence needs a number, an action and a time. Give them all three and they can walk out of your conversation straight into that one.

THE SHAPE UNDERNEATH ALL FIVE

Every script on this page is the same three moves in the same order.

1 THE SIZE how big, and by when. A number or a date, never a feeling. 2 WHAT YOU DID the thing you already tried, so nobody has to ask. 3 THE ASK what you need, from whom, by when.

If you have to say something and you cannot remember any of the wording above, say those three in that order and you will be close enough.

WHEN TO SAY IT

The timing decides whether the conversation is a decision or an announcement. A date at risk with four weeks left is frightening and there is still something anyone can do about it. The same date with four days left is just news.

If you are wondering whether it is too early to raise something, it is not.